PATRON RELATIONS

Old Town
Historical Society



Version 1.1 | 2026-11-01 | Current

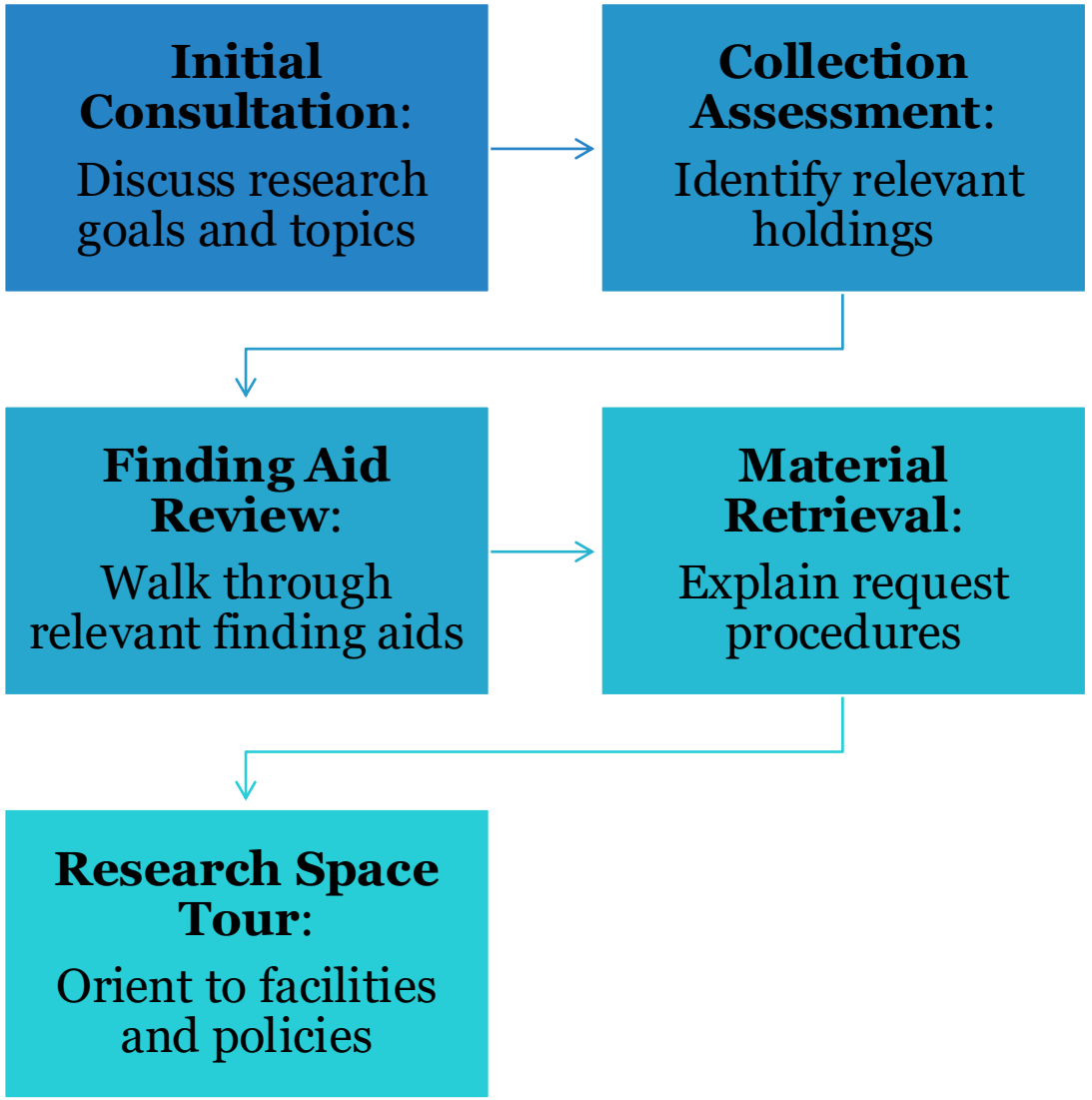
Learning Objectives



- Guide patrons effectively through archive navigation and finding aids
- Assist patrons with digital tools and technology resources
- Implement accessibility and inclusivity best practices
- Apply professional customer service skills in archive settings
- Handle challenging patron situations with confidence

Patron Orientation Process





Navigation Assistance

- Ask open-ended questions to understand research needs
- Explain the difference between archives and libraries
- Demonstrate how to interpret finding aids
- Provide realistic timelines for material retrieval
- Offer alternative collections when primary sources aren't available



Finding Aids and Research Tools

Finding aids are the roadmap to archival collections

Collection Overview: Scope, dates, and significance

Biographical/Historical Note: Context about the creator

Series Descriptions: How materials are organized

Container Lists: Box-by-box, folder-by-folder inventory



Digital Catalog Systems





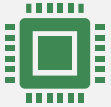
Catalog Search Techniques:
Boolean operators, field searching, filters



Database Navigation:
Moving between records, saving searches



Digital Collections:
Accessing online materials and metadata



Cross-Platform Searching:
Using multiple databases effectively

Patron Technology Support



BASIC COMPUTER SKILLS:

FILE MANAGEMENT, PRINTING, SAVING



DIGITAL CAMERA/SCANNER USE:

REPRODUCING ARCHIVAL MATERIALS



ONLINE RESEARCH:

DATABASE SEARCHING, DIGITAL COLLECTIONS



EQUIPMENT TROUBLESHOOTING:

BASIC TECHNICAL SUPPORT

Digital Preservation Awareness



- Why some materials may not be available digitally
- Copyright and use restrictions
- Quality standards for digital reproduction
- Long-term preservation considerations

Implementing Technology Training





Provide hands-on practice with all patron-facing systems



Create quick reference guides for common tasks



Establish protocols for technical difficulties



Maintain updated equipment and software

Understanding Accessibility Needs

Physical Disabilities:

Mobility challenges, wheelchair access

Visual Impairments:

Magnification needs, screen readers

Hearing Impairments:

Communication accommodations

Cognitive Differences:

Processing time, instruction clarity

Temporary Limitations:

Injuries, medical conditions

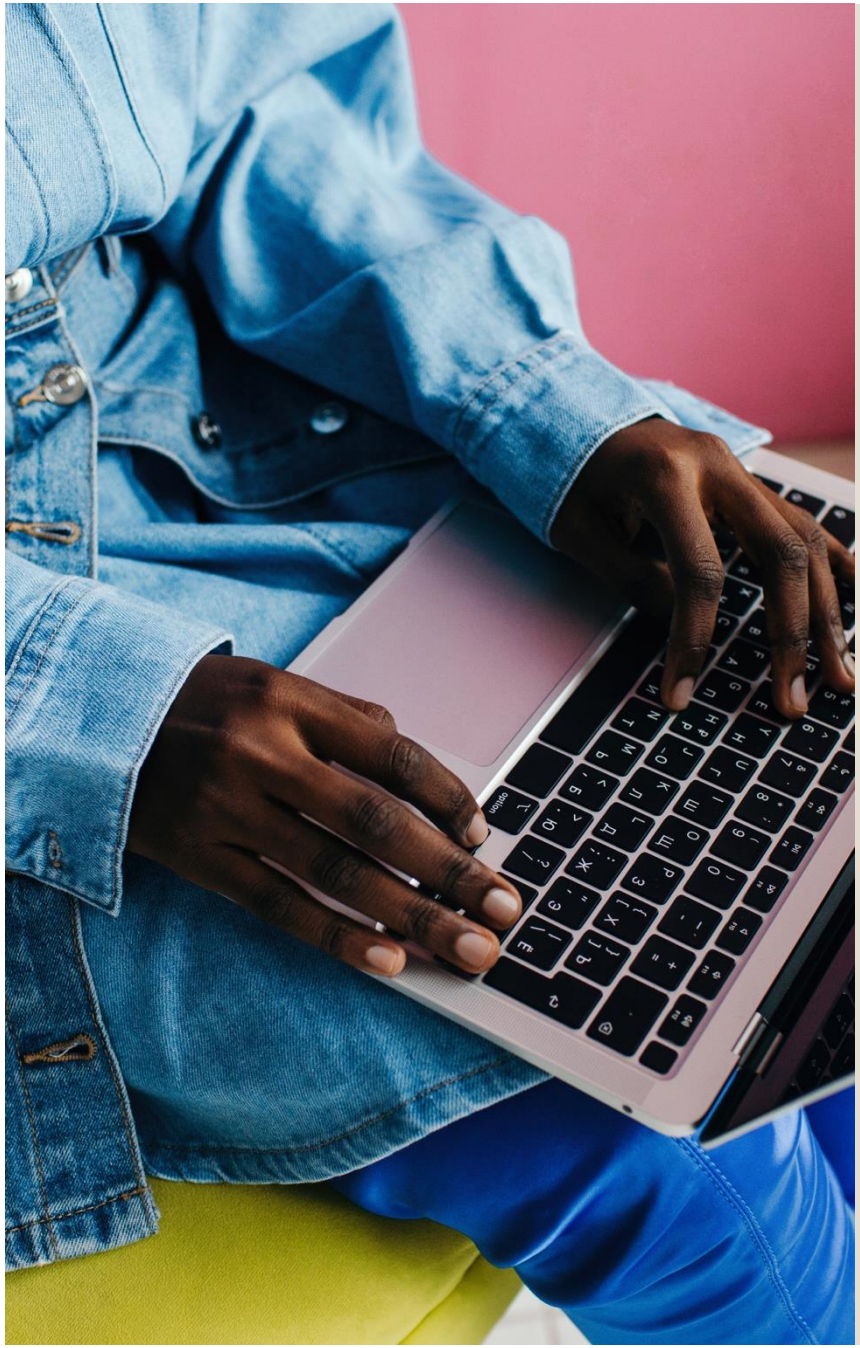


Physical Accessibility

Ensure research spaces accommodate:

- Wheelchair access to all public areas
- Adjustable tables and seating
- Adequate lighting and magnification tools
- Clear pathways and signage
- Accessible restrooms and facilities





Digital Accessibility

Online resources should include:

- Screen reader compatibility
- Keyboard navigation options
- Alternative text for images
- Captioned videos and audio
- Multiple format options

Inclusive Service Approaches





USE PERSON-FIRST LANGUAGE



ASK BEFORE PROVIDING ASSISTANCE



RESPECT ASSISTIVE DEVICES AND PERSONAL SPACE



OFFER MULTIPLE COMMUNICATION METHODS



PROVIDE EXTRA TIME WHEN NEEDED



CREATE WELCOMING, NON-JUDGMENTAL ENVIRONMENTS

Cultural Sensitivity

Historical societies serve diverse communities. Staff should:

Recognize	Understand	Provide	Respect	Acknowledge
Recognize potential cultural barriers	Understand sensitive historical topics	Provide context for historical materials	Respect different research approaches	Acknowledge gaps in historical records

Professional Communication



Active Listening:
Understanding patron needs completely

Clear Communication:
Explaining procedures and limitations

Patience:
Allowing time for questions and learning

Empathy:
Recognizing research frustrations

Professionalism:
Maintaining appropriate boundaries



Managing Patron Expectations

- **Time Requirements**: Research takes longer than expected
- **Material Availability**: Not everything is digitized or accessible
- **Copyright Restrictions**: Limitations on reproduction
- **Collection Scope**: Archives may not have everything patrons need
- **Processing Times**: New acquisitions may not be available immediately

Handling Difficult Situations





UNREALISTIC DEMANDS:

WANTING IMMEDIATE ACCESS TO RESTRICTED MATERIALS



FRUSTRATION WITH TECHNOLOGY:

DIFFICULTY USING DIGITAL SYSTEMS



DISAGREEMENT WITH POLICIES:

QUESTIONING ACCESS OR REPRODUCTION RULES



TIME PRESSURE:

RUSHED RESEARCH TIMELINES



EMOTIONAL RESPONSES:

STRONG REACTIONS TO HISTORICAL MATERIALS

De-escalation Strategies

- **Remain Calm**: Keep your voice steady and professional
- **Listen Actively**: Let patrons express their concerns fully
- **Acknowledge Feelings**: Validate their frustration
- **Focus on Solutions**: Explore alternatives within policies
- **Know When to Escalate**: Involve supervisors when necessary



Building Positive Relationships

Consistent Service:
Reliable, professional interactions

Personal Interest:
Showing genuine enthusiasm for their research

Follow-up:
Checking in on research progress

Resource Sharing:
Suggesting additional materials or repositories

Feedback:
Asking for input on services and improvements



Implementation

Staff Development

**Regular Training Sessions:* Monthly skill-building workshops

**Peer Mentoring*: Pairing experienced staff with new hires

**Professional Development*: Attending conferences and workshops

**Cross-Training*: Ensuring multiple staff can handle various tasks

**Performance Feedback:* Regular evaluation and improvement planning

Policy Development

Create clear, written policies for:

* Patron Relations and orientation

*Material access and handling

*Technology use and support

*Accessibility accommodations

*Customer service standards

Implementation

Quality Assurance

**Patron Feedback:* Regular surveys and comment opportunities

**Staff Observations*: Periodic evaluation of patron interactions

**Service Metrics*: Tracking satisfaction and efficiency

**Continuous Improvement:* Regular policy and procedure updates

Emergency Procedures

Staff should be prepared for:

*Medical emergencies in research spaces

*Technology failures during patron visits

*Difficult patron situations requiring intervention

*Natural disasters or building emergencies

Thank You!



"Alone we can do so little; together we can do so much."

— Helen Keller